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TRUMP RAISES THE NUCLEAR STAKES

The US president's call to resume tests has shaken a fragile non-proliferation order, raising the spectre of a new arms race

BY RAKESH SOOD

On October 30, US president Donald Trump shocked the world, including his own nuclear establishment, by announcing on Truth Social that he had "instructed the Department of War to start testing our Nuclear Weapons on an equal basis. That process will begin immediately". His justification was that Russia and China were engaged in testing nuclear weapons and while "Russia is second, and China is a distant third, but will be even within 5 years".

The confusion generated was palpable. The same day, appearing for confirmation hearings before Senate Armed Forces Committee, Vice Admiral Richard Correll, nominated as head of the Strategic Command, when asked about Trump's announcement, affirmed full confidence in the "reliability" of the US nuclear arsenal (the STRATCOM certifies it annually in January) only to add that "I wouldn't presume the President's words mean nuclear testing", maintaining that he was "not reading anything into it or reading anything out".

The confusion was compounded because the US nuclear labs and the Nevada test site fall under the Department of Energy and not the Pentagon. Second, while Russia and China have been developing new weapons, neither has carried out an explosive test; they have tested delivery systems.

On October 21, Russia tested a nuclear-powered cruise missile, Burevestnik, followed a week later by a nuclear-powered underwater drone (Poseidon), somewhat like a torpedo. China has been testing hypersonic missiles and, in 2021, tested a nuclear-capable hypersonic glide vehicle carried on a rocket, capable of orbiting Earth before approaching its target from an unexpected direction, passing it off as a satellite launcher.

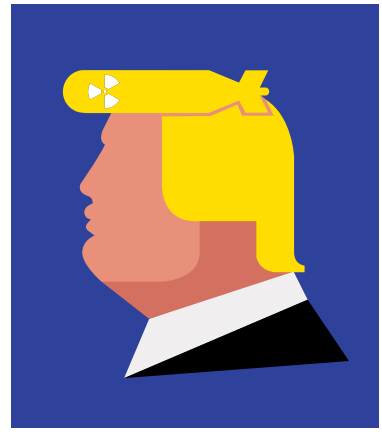

Illustration by RAJ VERMA

A NEW CYCLE OF EXPLOSIVE TESTING WILL KILL THE UNENFORCEABLE CTBT, BUT INDIA HARDLY NEEDS TO SHED ANY TEARS FOR IT

In his testimony, Admiral Correll stated, "To my knowledge, the last explosive nuclear testing was by North Korea, and that was in 2017. But Russia and China have not done an explosion that we know of." Was Trump mixing up weapon system tests with nuclear explosive tests?

In a TV interview on November 2, Trump doubled down on resuming nuclear testing, this time including Pakistan and North Korea among the countries that are testing. The pushback came the same day from energy secretary Chris Wright on Fox News, calling the US tests 'systems tests'. "These are not nuclear explosions. These are what we call noncritical explosions," he said.

Russia's last explosive test was in 1990, while the US declared a moratorium on tests in 1992. In 1993, President Bill Clinton took the lead in pushing negotiations in Geneva for a Comprehensive Test Ban Treaty (CTBT). China and France concluded their tests in 1996, six months before the negotiations ended. Even though 187 countries have signed on to it, it has failed to enter into force. China and the US have not ratified it, and Russia withdrew its ratification in 2023. India, Pakistan and North Korea never joined; while India and Pakistan tested in 1998, North Korea conducted six tests between 2006 and 2017.

A new cycle of explosive testing will kill the flawed and unenforceable CTBT, but India hardly needs to shed any tears for it. It has been observing a voluntary moratorium, but if explosive testing resumes, India will seek to validate its boosted fission and thermonuclear designs with tests. Undoubtedly, Pakistan will follow, though given its growing strategic linkages with China, as witnessed during Operation Sindoor, this need hardly add to our concerns. A resumption of explosive testing will certainly tempt the nuclear wannabes and mark the unravelling of the NPT-led non-proliferation regime.

The sole surviving US-Russia arms control agreement, New START, is due to expire on February 4, 2026, and there are no prospects of any talks on the horizon. An incipient nuclear arms race was already underway; a resumption of explosive testing will just take the lid off. Trump has just raised the global nuclear stakes. And there may be many takers. ■

The writer is a former diplomat, and a foreign policy and strategic affairs expert